Ambivalent sexism in *Skyfall*

"To what extent does the characterisation of females in the James Bond film *Skyfall* reflect concepts of ambivalent sexism?"

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Table of Contents

Introduction	2
Discussion: Analysis of ambivalent sexism *Skyfall*	6
Previous Research	11
Conclusion	14

Introduction

The normalisation of sexism has severe consequences in a world where women are increasingly fighting for equal rights (European Union, 2017). The topic of sexism is significant globally, as it can be seen in all aspects of life in all countries, in a multitude of ways (Glick & Fiske, 2001). Women are affected by sexism in the workplace, with less job opportunities and a clear wage gap (European Union, 2017; Stamarski & Son Hing, 2015). Sexism is also evident in home life, with women being expected to take on roles of childcare and housework. Stereotypes about women have caused a lack of education, with about one quarter of girls not having education in the developing world (UNICEF, n.d.). These stereotypes and absence of education can cause a deficiency in healthcare and jobs, leading to a continuous cycle of abuse and discrimination (World Health Organization, 2021). Stereotypes may be reinforced by different types of media that endorse sexist attitudes, which may ultimately provoke violence against women (Bussey & Bandura, 1999; Coyne et al., 2016; Herrett-Skjellum & Allen, 1996).

Ambivalent sexism is a theory suggested by Glick and Fiske (1996) that proposes two components of sexism: hostile and benevolent sexism. Gender hierarchy and power differences are the causing factor for hostility, whereas intimacy and interdependence generate benevolence (Gaunt, 2013). Hostile sexism is an overtly misogynistic and antagonistic attitude toward women, where negative stereotypes are sustained. This often includes the idea that women try to manipulate and control men by sexual means (Glick & Fiske, 2001). One of the aims of hostile sexism is to safeguard the dominance and power of men over women. Women who stray from stereotypically feminine characteristics are resented, as they are perceived to jeopardise the authority of men (Begany & Milburn, 2002, as cited in Mastari et al., 2019).

Benevolent sexism is a disguisedly positive belief that women must be protected and cared for, due to the value of their stereotypical traits, such as nurturance. Benevolent sexism may be erroneously recognised as chivalry due to the description of women as innocent, fragile, and loving (Glick & Fiske, 2001; Grubbs, n.d.). Protection from men is only available as a reward to those women who comply with traditional roles, stemming from patronising and conservative beliefs that all women are angelic and pure (Connelly & Heesacker, 2012, as cited in Mastari et al., 2019). Benevolent and hostile sexism are complementary attitudes that penalise the violation of traditional gender roles and reward conforming to stereotypes (Daniels & Leaper, 2011; Mastari et al., 2019). Hostile and benevolent sexism are ubiquitous cross-culturally, but their balance varies based on values of each culture. Customarily, women tend to spurn hostile behaviour, whereas they may be more inclined to tolerate benevolent sexism, especially in harshly sexist countries, as benevolent sexism is often thought of as protection from domestic violence (Glick & Fiske, 2001; Mastari et al., 2019). Both benevolent and hostile sexism are present in the film *Skyfall* (Mendes, 2012), where benevolent sexism may be mistaken for the chivalry of Bond, and hostile sexism is also presented in a disguised way.

Western film is crucial in the context of shaping gender attitudes, as it has a normalising power that can reinforce stereotypes and form new attitudes toward women (Bussey & Bandura, 1999; Coyne et al., 2016; Herrett-Skjellum & Allen, 1996). It is evident that women are under-represented in media such as film, and often portrayed in an overly sexual, negative, and stereotyped manner (Collins, 2011; Neurendorf et al., 2010; Smith et al., 2014). Different types of media have become essential in most people's lives, as a tool of communication and entertainment. This importance has given films an increasing power to influence viewers, in both positive and negative ways, as the Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) (Bandura, 1986) proposes that humans learn through observation (Bussey & Bandura, 1999). The mechanism of modelling suggested in SCT also pertains to learning gendered behaviour, as children develop

concepts of gender through role models, including fictional characters on television (Bussey & Bandura, 1999; Coyne et al., 2016; Herrett-Skjellum & Allen, 1996; Hylmö, 2006). This theory is significant in terms of sexist attitudes and behaviours, as they are easily adopted via films such as the Bond franchise. Viewers observe sexist behaviour in a character they look up to, like James Bond, and see it being supported. Thus, films can make susceptible viewers believe what they are seeing is socially acceptable, such as sexist attitudes and female stereotypes (Bussey & Bandura, 1999).

For over five decades, fictional character James Bond has held an iconic role in filmmaking, becoming a global phenomenon. The British secret agent, known for his car chases and association with beautiful women, has been the inspiration for a myriad of other fictional characters (Auralcrave, 2021). The character was first introduced in 1953 in Flemming's novel Casino Royale, and first appeared on-screen in Dr. No (1962), launching the well-known James Bond movie franchise. Over the years, Bond has been portrayed by multiple actors, with Daniel Craig adopting the role in 2006 (Britannica, 2021).

Though Bond is a global phenomenon, the franchise has strong roots in Great Britain, where it is locally significant (Sabbagh, 2021). Bond undoubtedly displays British customs and culture, including the concept of gender roles and attitudes toward women. The twenty-third James Bond movie, *Skyfall*, directed by Sam Mendes (2012), is packed with acknowledgements of British culture, with a backdrop in both London and Scotland. Due to globalisation and the world's awareness of Bond, the embodiment of local stereotypes becomes significant globally, as customs and ideals are being spread.

Although there has been legislation to prevent sexism in Britain, such as the Sex Discrimination act of 2002 and Equality Acts of 2006 and 2010, it is still prevalent in the culture, with children already having gendered associations for careers, toys, and behaviours

(Eccles et al., 2000; European Union, 2022; Hylmö, 2006). Although the pay gap is narrowing and female representation across careers has increased, many women are still holding back from certain careers due to stereotypes established early in life (Equality and Human Rights Commission, 2019). As norms and sexist attitudes, especially those in Great Britain, begin to change, the film industry follows (Brewington et al., 2022). This can be observed in the slight changes of the James Bond franchise over time, as sexist comments have slowly been made more obscure, and new aims of progressiveness have been introduced in the Craig era (Britannica, 2021). Although the contemporary films are still highly sexist, the modern British views on sexism have caused them to be more nuanced.

The aim of this investigation is to further understand and outline the ways in which films build sexist stereotypes. This globally significant subject will be investigated through the film *Skyfall* (Mendes, 2012), a case study which portrays sexism in Great Britain. An interdisciplinary approach will be utilised with the application of concepts from both subjects of Psychology and English. This combination is necessary as it allows an in-depth analysis of the semantic methods for reinforcing ambivalent sexism. Concepts of English literature analysis will be put into practice in the analysis of select scenes and characters, in order to discover how characterisation constructs stereotypes and sexism. These stereotypical tropes, as well as other authorial choices, will be examined from a psychological point of view and evaluated in relation to how they uphold constructs of ambivalent sexism. Thus, the research question of the present essay is: **To what extent does the characterisation of females in the James Bond film *Skyfall* reinforce concepts of ambivalent sexism?**

Discussion: Analysis of ambivalent sexism in *Skyfall*

The James Bond movie *Skyfall* (Mendes, 2012), begins with Bond on a mission with his secretary Moneypenny, trying to capture a mercenary. Moneypenny accidentally shoots Bond, who falls into a river and is presumed dead. Back in England, M, the head of the Secret Intelligence Service MI6, is being pressured to retire and is threatened as the MI6 building explodes. Bond, who is still alive and living in paradise, learns of the attack and returns home to England, after which he is soon sent on a new mission to uncover the identity of the mercenary's employer, and bring him to England. Along the way, Bond meets former sex slave Severine at a casino, and with her help is led to Raoul Silva, a former employee of M in MI6, and the main antagonist of the film. After many complications, Silva is returned to England, however, he escapes and plans to kill M, who has gone into hiding with Bond at his old estate in Scotland.

Skyfall (Mendes, 2012), similarly to all prior Bond films, features multiple women as supporting characters. Each film in the franchise introduces one or more "Bond girl", who is commonly romantically involved with Bond. She may either have a pivotal role in the plot, or simply be there for sex appeal. Generally, a "Bond girl" fits into one of four categories: the lover, who simply has sexual relations with Bond, the sidekick, who helps Bond in his missions, the sacrificial lamb, who dies in a gruesome way to provoke Bond, and the femme fatale, a seducive antagonist. These character tropes are formed from stereotypes, and are consistently portrayed in a sexist manner as women are either being shown as manipulative and a threat to men, or their weakness is highlighted through stereotypical traits (Sibley & Wilson, 2004).

As an important link to the local manifestation of sexism in Britain, Eve Moneypenny's role as the traditional British secretary reflects ambivalent sexism in terms of stereotypes.

Throughout the franchise, Bond has been admired by the character of Moneypenny, previously a white, highly feminine secretary, a typical British stereotype that is seen in a vast range of media. *Skyfall* (Mendes, 2012) begins in a seemingly progressive way, as Moneypenny is a field agent working with Bond, and is played by a Black actress for the first time. However, this progressiveness is promptly curtailed, as Moneypenny accidentally shoots Bond and he is presumed dead (Mendes, 2012, 0:12:05). As Bond returns to England, Moneypenny is reminded of her failure, with Bond making sarcastic remarks: "Well, you gave it your best shot" (Mendes 2012, 0:34:24), implying that her best try is still a failed one. She is immediately suspended from further field work, losing the chance to change the stereotype. She retreats to her sexist role as the flirty secretary, seemingly unsuitable for more demanding work. Throughout the film, Moneypenny and Bond continuously flirt with each other, with Bond unbuttoning her shirt while being shaved (Mendes, 2012, 0:54:19), and Moneypenny making a jealous remark about his flirting with Severine (Mendes, 2012, 0:59:30). This keeps up the idea that her character is crushing on Bond, just like every other woman in the franchise. Moneypenny's character being stuck in the secretary role reinforces sexist beliefs, specifically those of hostile sexism that posit that women are not capable of doing challenging work, and certain careers must be left for men. Moneypenny is the embodiment of British stereotypes in film, and she aligns with the widespread belief that careers are gendered, which is learnt at an early age especially in Britain (Equality and Human Rights Commission, 2019).

It is crucial to study the character of M, as her portrayal consists of numerous elements of ambivalent sexism, despite the fact that she is often regarded as the strong, independent woman in Bond films. M is the head of Secret Intelligence Service also known as MI6, and is James Bond's boss. Her role as a "Bond girl" is questionable as she shares no romantic scenes with Bond, although her central role in *Skyfall* may qualify her as Bond's sidekick. To begin with, the death of M reinforces ideas of both hostile and benevolent sexism. As she dies in

Bond's arms at the end of the film, she stoops to the level of a helpless woman in need of Bond's protection, accentuating his positive characteristics (Mendes, 2012, 2:14:12). Her vulnerability and need for protection align with benevolent sexism, as Bond feels the need to save her, which highlights his toughness and ability to protect others. M's powerless position contradicts all of her independence and power as seen earlier in the film, virtually reversing the idea that she is a strong woman who does not need Bond's saviour.

Even though M's authority can be seen as a step forward in female representation in film, her characterisation can nevertheless be interpreted as hostile sexism. As she has short hair and is more masculine than the stereotypical woman featured in Bond films, she may not be viewed as a "real" woman by the male characters, therefore given power. This ties to the fear of women trying to take away men's power, as M's femininity is downplayed. Her appearance and personality imply that only masculine women can do powerful things, also linking traits of weakness and deficiency with femininity. Furthermore, theories of hostile sexism predict that men are threatened by non-feminine women, as they are perceived as a threat to male dominance, and thus resent them (Begany & Milburn, 2002, as cited in Mastari et al., 2019). Accordingly, M's leadership is undermined by multiple male characters throughout the film, which can be interpreted as men seeing her as a threat. Her older age and gender are regularly reiterated, with mentions that she is an unfit leader with poor judgement. The main antagonist, Silva, refers to M as "that old woman" (Mendes, 2012, 1:12:56), as he tries to persuade Bond into thinking she is inadequate and scheming. He also adds, "at least here there are no old women giving orders" (Mendes, 2012, 1:16:00), highlighting her gender and age as a way to downplay her capability for leadership. The constant emphasis on M's gender and age in relation to her capability is a manifestation of the hostile fear of women taking over men's leadership roles.

A peculiar mother-son relationship arises between M and her agents, as M is presented almost as a maternal figure to Bond, and previously had been the same with Silva before she abandoned him (Wright, 2012). As Silva explains M's wrongdoings to Bond, Bond remains faithful to M, saying "She never lied to me" (Mendes, 2012, 1:13:00) displaying that they had a trustful relationship. Silva then reveals that he saw her as a motherly figure: "Mommy was very bad" (Mendes, 2012, 1:14:00), and also calls her "Mother", after being captured in England (Mendes, 2012, 1:24:48). This reveals the dynamic between the agents and M, which is accentuated as Bond reminds M that his parents are dead, and M confesses: "Orphans make the best recruits" (Mendes, 2012, 1:46:53). This maternal role highlights the benevolently sexist idea that all women are nurturing and maternal, and that women in positions of authority can often be seen more as mothers than leaders.

The character of Severine is presented in an ambivalently sexist manner through her indirect characterisation and role in the film. She is the primary "Bond girl" in *Skyfall* (Mendes, 2012), fitting into multiple stereotypes that reinforce ambivalent sexism. Firstly, she fits into the sexist 'femme fatale' trope due to her role of leading Bond to the main antagonist, Silva. As a common attribute of the femme fatale, Severine is the mistress of the antagonist, and is commanded to seduce Bond in order to get him killed. While some may view the archetype of the femme fatale as empowering for women, as they are comfortable with their sexuality and femininity, Severine's original plan of letting her guards kill Bond gives the impression that all independent women are scheming and controlling, a belief of hostile sexism. Despite Severine's change of heart, the underlying fact that she was commanded to seduce and have Bond killed leaves the sense that men believe that women are manipulative. Severine's fit into the femme fatale trope reinforces the idea that women use sexual means to exploit men, a concept of hostile sexism.

Different aspects of ambivalent sexism are presented in how Severine is graphically murdered following her intimate relations with Bond. To begin with, Bond's seduction efforts seem ill-advised as viewers are aware of Severine's past of sex trade, prompting questions about how women are viewed in the film. Even after discovering her depressing background, Bond believes it is appropriate to have a sexual encounter with her, taking advantage of her vulnerability as he sneaks into her shower while she clearly looks nervous (Mendes, 2012, 1:06:20). As a recurring and appalling component of Bond films, almost all of Bond's lovers die before the end of the film, becoming "sacrificial lambs". After being seduced by Bond and leading him to Silva, Severine's purpose seems to be fulfilled, thus is killed off. After Severine brings Bond to Silva, she is tied up and beaten, and Silva forces her to kiss him. Silva kills her by placing a glass of scotch on her head, and shooting her (Mendes, 2012, 1:20:00). Though Bond may have been shaken by this action, his reaction of "It's a waste of good scotch" hints that she meant nothing to him. The scene leaves a certain ambiguity about Bond's true reaction and thoughts on Severine's death, allowing viewers to interpret whether or not he cared. Severine acts as a foil to Bond, as she is portrayed as weak and fragile while Bond's toughness and masculinity are accentuated. Especially as these traits of fragility are used in order to accentuate Bond's strength, the hostile belief that men are superior to women is highlighted. Not only does this series of events kindle negative stereotypes of women being weak, it advocates the idea of toxic masculinity, strengthening harmful stereotypes of both genders. In light of her past of sex trade, Severine's brutal way of death, her seduction, and the forced kiss imply that she is valued in no way. As she is seemingly disposable and not mentioned for the rest of the film, it appears that Bond did not care for her and only used her for his own good. The omission of her character for the rest of the film reestablishes the idea that women are simply sex objects who have no further significance. Severine's death in the film links to the hostile belief that women are worth less than men, and gives the impression that treating women in such a manner is acceptable.

The lack of characterisation of Bond's nameless lover continues the idea that women are nothing more than sex objects to be used by Bond. This character appears on screen for approximately 25 seconds and has no lines; she is only pictured in bed with Bond, while he is enjoying paradise while presumed dead (Mendes, 2012, 1:22:02). Similarly to the character of Severine, she is used as a foil character to accentuate the positive traits of Bond, assuring the viewers that Bond still has all of his charm despite his injury. Her lack of presence, name, speech, and other personality traits further maintains the hostile belief that women are no more than sex objects meant to entertain men. She is another character who is simply dismissed and forgotten about once her purpose of entertaining Bond has been fulfilled. Her role as the nameless lover also contributes to attitudes of benevolent sexism, as she is seen as nurturing and caring, comforting Bond while he ignores her. While these are not negative traits, the deficiency of other personality traits reinforces negative stereotypes, upholding ideas of both benevolent and hostile sexism.

Previous research

Examining the research done on sexism in the film industry is relevant in this investigation, as it allows understanding on the effects of sexist attitudes in *Skyfall* on its viewers. Research on sexism in film has revealed that not only do films portray women in a sexist and negative way, they have the ability to impact the attitudes of viewers and spread ambivalently sexist attitudes (Aubrey & Harrison, 2009; Bussey & Bandura, 1999; Collins, 2011; Coyne et al., 2016; Smith et al., 2014).

A study by Smith et al (2014) examined the portrayal of women in the 600 top-grossing films from 2007-2013, finding that only 28% of the selected films had a female lead. The study also found that about 30% of all females shown in the films were portrayed in a sexual manner, with either partial or full nudity. In terms of *Skyfall*, Severine is depicted in a sexual manner with partial nudity when she appears in the film. Another meta-analysis of various studies concerning the relationship between media and gender stereotypes found that television content consists of large amounts of sexual stereotypes (Herrett-Skjellum & Allen, 1996). The study also found that acceptance of stereotypical images of women increased in line with watching television, suggesting that television has the ability to reinforce and develop stereotypes. A study by Coyne et al. (2016) found that higher exposure to Disney princesses was related to adherence to gender-stereotypical behaviour in children. The results of these studies entail that films can largely develop stereotypes about females for both men and women, with men possibly embracing sexist attitudes, and women conforming to traditional roles. This means that a film like *Skyfall* has the potential to reinforce stereotypes to easily-susceptible viewers, and those sexist attitudes should be identified in order to minimise their spread.

The display of female stereotypes in the James Bond franchise has been studied, and it is clear that Bond films reinforce negative stereotypes against women. A content analysis of the first 20 James Bond films revealed the different predictors among women for sexual activity and mortality in the films (Neuendorf et al., 2010). A qualitative analysis was performed by coding each female character from all 20 films regarding descriptive indicators such as age, race, and physical appearance. Their involvement in sexual activity, enduring of physical harm, as well as end-of-film mortality was measured. These variables were coded against each other to find the relationship between them. Concerning sexual activity in female characters, the study found that attractiveness, small body size, a major role in the film, and use of weapons were

all significant predictors. Similarly, the study also found that harm to the female in the film was significantly predicted by extreme attractiveness, major role in film, sexual activity, as well as weapon use. Finally, the predictors for end-of-film mortality in female characters was measured, and the researchers found that sexual activity, attempts to kill Bond, weapon use, and being an antagonist at the end of the film were significant.

Though this study does not examine the most recent films starring Daniel Craig, which are presumed to be more progressive than the preceding films, the basic trends of the franchise are outlined, which can be recognised in the contemporary films. As seen from the results of this exploration, the actions and fate of female characters in a copious amount of Bond films follow trends based on their characteristics. As mortality is predicted by high sexual activity, it can be seen that Bond films follow a gruesome trend of killing off love interests. While the circumstances of each instance are not specified, it seems that the franchise views women as nothing more than sex objects, who are discarded after they have fulfilled their duty, as they are believed to have nothing more to offer. In the case of *Skyfall*, the main love interest, former sex slave Severine is sadistically killed after being beaten and tied up. The predictors for sexual activity are also eye opening, as women with a major role in the film are significantly predicted to have sexual interactions with Bond, also suggesting that women are nothing more than sex objects, as in order to have significant screen time, they must engage in sexual activity. Though these results are correlational and do not establish causal relationships, the exceptions to this prediction should be considered. M and Moneypenny, who have major roles in the films, do not engage in sexual activity. However, when it comes to M, it can be argued that she does not fit into the other characteristics that predict sexual activity. This is significant, as one of the main ideas of ambivalent sexism is that the violation of traditional roles is penalised, whereas conforming to stereotypes is supported (Daniels & Leaper, 2011; Mastari et al., 2019).

Conclusion

Although it can be argued that the world is largely stepping in the right direction concerning gender equality, accurate and positive representation in film is a crucial step that needs to be put into practice worldwide, in order to stray away from negative stereotypes that ultimately harm the health of women globally (Brewington et al., 2022; Herrett-Skjellum & Allen, 1996).

Through the interdisciplinary perspectives of English and Psychology, this investigation found that authorial choices featured in the film *Skyfall* (Mendes, 2012) reinforce concepts of ambivalent sexism through indirect characterisation. Stereotypes in *Skyfall*, a case study of sexism in Britain, are constructed mainly by fitting female characters into typical character tropes. The role of each character, whether they are a big part in the film or simply there to accentuate Bond's qualities, determines the extent to which they are linked to attitudes of ambivalent sexism. Sexism in *Skyfall* is indisputable, whether the characters are facing normalised sexism, or they embody internalised sexist attitudes. This case study reflects the underlying sexist attitudes of Britain, a local manifestation of sexism worldwide.

Though it cannot be said that all films are deliberately sexist or promote a sexist agenda, it is clear that sexism, whether benevolent or hostile, is largely apparent and normalised in the film industry (Brewington et al., 2022; Herrett-Skjellum & Allen, 1996). Whilst this investigation studied sexist attitudes against women, the display of gender stereotypes in media is just as damaging to men, with toxic masculinity being a prevalent topic (Giaccardi et al., 2016). The normalisation of harmful stereotypes and beliefs can be detrimental to the feminist

movement, and slowly halt the progression of equality in our modern world as people adopt the attitudes they view on-screen.

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